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Some self-crowned pundits had expected the worst. I never subscribed to that prediction. Thus, I believe markets are now realising that things are not so bad and will not be that bad.

A sizeable part of the Indian economy consists of "non-discretionary, non-leveraged" spending. Hence, it was really not going to be so bad at all.

Indian economy is neither coupled nor decoupled with the global economy. Some Hindu rate of growth can always come from the decoupled players/sectors in India.

It might take some time for India to dream of double digit growth again. Maybe after the world gets back to its pre-shock state. But a baseline 6-7 per cent growth is assured.

Consumer spending pulse of the marketplace is a sign to keep an eye on. Phone calls from credit card companies or banks giving consumer loans may be other indicators.



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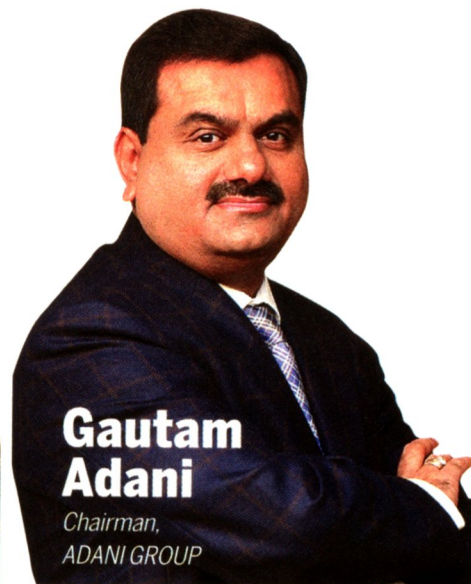
Gains in the stock market are not really indicative of a decided course correction. The gains have coincided with a 14-year low in industrial output and a record 19 per cent plunge in merchandise shipments.

Merchandise exports and imports, and services are highly integrated globally. Liquidity is still tight. If we weave all these together, the canvas is not so rosy.

In some sectors, there may be a limited impact of the global carnage. While we might just about log 6 per cent growth in FY10, as the RBI says, the challenge very much remains.

Over the past two years, everyone has gone wrong in reading the crystal ball; I do not wish to be added to that list.

For unmistakable signs, we must look at industries that sell to consumers with a large credit appetite—big-ticket items, such as cars and homes. Look at a trend reversal in bus/truck sales that plunged 22 per cent in the last fiscal.



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The rise in markets is certainly not an illusion because it is born out of a strong political stability factor which appears to be real.

Yes, certainly, because this revival is based on strong political stability. But still we have to be cautious as there are global factors that are partially involved.

Yes, we have to see India differently because of strong local factors.

About six months, if the new government goes about its task properly.

Increase in employment generation, which is the surest indicator. So, we have to keep an eye on the employment scenario.

- Give another stimulus package for increasing demand, production and jobs.
- Make a 10-year agenda and road map for 10 per cent growth and follow it.
- Rationalise government expenditure and subsidies to control fiscal deficit.

- Decide between deficit and stimulus—the choice is obvious.
- Promote investments and spur projects through incentives and credit flows to bring India's growth back on track.

- Increase spending on infrastructure.
- Reduce interest rates to 7.5 from the current 10 to 12 per cent.
- Identify certain infrastructure segments that can create large-scale employment and put them on fast track.